EL NIÑO ACTION BRIEFING · 8 OCTOBER 2026

Gaslamp Quarter, downtown San Diego

El Niño reaches San Diego as rain, not heat: atmospheric rivers that fill the river and creek channels where unsheltered people sleep, and flood the shelters meant to receive them. The most important step is to walk those channels in person before every Flood Watch.

IMPACT REGION	EXCESS HEAT DEATHS	WINDOW	DOMINANT HAZARD
San Diego County, CA (inferred)	None published for the US, California, or the county	n/a here; global 6-month figure 239,000 ± 11,000	Flood from atmospheric rivers, plus cold and wet exposure of unsheltered people

11/11 recommendations checked. 9 corrected, 0 unverified, 2 contraindicated as written (blanket suspension of camping enforcement, and a rain-gauge parametric policy). None survived exactly as proposed. The four funding placements were checked separately: 1 contraindicated (a $720k shelter-bed expansion the sites cannot physically hold) and 1 unverified. **The funding target fell 32.5%**, from $1.32M to about $892k. That is just under the one-third flag, so treat it as borderline. Exposure: Climate Impact Lab, 451,000 at Risk, September 2026, pre-peer-review. It publishes no figure for the United States, California, or San Diego County, and heat is not this place's El Niño hazard. No population-scaled figure is given here, because scaling a heat number onto a flood hazard would be meaningless.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY — AT A GLANCE



32.71°N 117.16°W, United States of America · Natural Earth

- **The risk.** El Niño arrives as rain, not heat: atmospheric rivers fill the river and creek channels where unsheltered people sleep, and flood the shelters meant to receive them.
- **First action.** PATH San Diego, San Diego River Park Foundation, Park Rangers, and Lifeguards survey the channels by 15 November, then walk them in person 24–48 hours before every Flood Watch.
- **The money.** $250k floor, about $891.5k target, about $1.66M ceiling; the floor pays $150k for outreach and $100k for naloxone staff, covering the two causes that kill people here.
- **Do not.** Do not suspend camping-ordinance enforcement across the board from November to March.

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* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Read this first: the Gaslamp is the wrong unit for the deaths. Five of the seven lenses reached the same conclusion independently. The Gaslamp's own streets saw no storm deaths or rescues in the record. The deaths and rescues happened in the San Diego River in Mission Valley (13 rescued during Hilary, August 2023), in Forester Creek in Santee (where Faith Angle, 46 and unhoused, was found after the 22 January 2024 storm), and at the 16th & Newton Bridge Shelter on the edge of East Village, which has flooded three times. The plan below is written for the people of this district wherever they are sleeping this winter, not for its buildings. One caveat cuts against the lenses: the City Auditor's April 2026 audit found that reported encampment locations “did not significantly change” after the 2023 camping ordinance. So the claim that people were pushed into the channels is weaker than the lenses assumed.

WHAT THIS PLACE SHOULD DO — RANKED

Actions are ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak. The backing lenses are shown on each action, and the RACI chart below assigns each one. An action several lenses reached independently is the stronger bet, but only where its evidence came from somewhere like here. One rule underlies every action: trigger on individual atmospheric-river forecasts, not on the season. The strong 2015–16 El Niño left San Diego with about 8 inches of rain, while the 2024 disaster was a single day.

1. Walk the San Diego River and creek channels in person 24–48 hours before every Flood Watch, after a full survey by 15 November

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · EMERGENCY MGR · FRONTLINE · SKEPTIC · HISTORIAN · ECONOMIST · PHILANTHROPIST

INVENTORY: INDIRECT ONLY (FORECAST QUALITY, SHRADER ET AL. 2023)

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
PATH San Diego and San Diego River Park Foundation, with Park Rangers and SDFD Lifeguards; Santee Sheriff and Fire for Forester Creek	Survey by 15 Nov; walks at each NWS Flood Watch	Existing programme, plus a ~$150k top-up (estimate, no published unit cost)	People swept away while sleeping in flood channels

The River Park Foundation already walks 24 miles of river with PATH and Park Rangers before storms, and in November 2025 it logged 323 people at flood risk along the river. The 2026 Point-in-Time Count found about 148 people in the riverbed. Its staff say plainly that “not everybody has access to a cell phone”. In January 2026, people in the channels were still learning about storms only once the rain had started. Tropical Storm Hilary (20 August 2023) needed 13 rescues from a single Mission Valley encampment. The action is to scale up

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

what already exists. That means a full channel census by 15 November, then walks with Spanish-speaking staff 24–48 hours ahead of each NWS flood product, offering transport and storage for belongings so that people do not refuse to move. The state Encampment Resolution Fund grants that paid for river outreach are expiring (KPBS, June 2026), so the top-up fills a real gap rather than duplicating money already committed.

Transferability: high, because the evidence comes from this place and this programme. What is missing is outcome evidence: no study measures deaths averted by pre-storm outreach. The record on deaths is also thinner than the lenses claimed. The Medical Examiner investigated three deaths as *possibly* storm-related after 22 January 2024, and Faith Angle's cause of death was still pending in the reports found. Forester Creek is in Santee, outside City jurisdiction, so it needs a separate owner.

2. Fix the shelter system before it floods again: a forecast trigger, daytime stay during multi-day storms, more activated nights, and a pre-planned move out of 16th & Newton

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · PUBLIC HEALTH · HISTORIAN · SKEPTIC · ECONOMIST · PHILANTHROPIST | INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
San Diego Housing Commission and City Homelessness Strategies & Solutions	**Evacuation plan by 1 Nov; trigger change by 1 Dec**	**~$641.5k for 60 extra activated nights (estimate; see funding)**	**Cold and wet exposure deaths, and another evacuation in the middle of a storm**

The Inclement Weather Shelter programme runs November to March with 162 beds. Father Joe's Villages provides 134 at 1501 Imperial Ave, and Living Water Church provides 28 at 1550 Market St, where reservations are taken 1–4pm and check-in is at 8pm. It activates below 50°F with a 40% or higher chance of rain, or at 45°F or lower. One inch of rain or more in 24 hours, or high wind, counts only as a discretionary “exceptional condition”. **So it already opens on rain, but only at the City's discretion and only once rain is falling.** What is missing is a trigger that fires on the *forecast*, from an NWS Flood Watch or an AR3+ atmospheric-river forecast. Utilisation averaged 69% in FY25, so the constraint is nights, not beds: there were about 53 activations out of 151 winter nights. The bigger exposure is the 16th & Newton Bridge Shelter. It flooded in 2018, in January 2024 (about $788k to repair), and again on 1 January 2026, when about 325 people were moved to the Balboa Park municipal gym. No relocation plan has been found. At minimum, write that move down now: the site, the cots, and an on-call MTS bus agreement.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: same place, same programme. No study gives an effect size for shelter activation on mortality. The case rests on the direct mechanism and the 2024 and 2026 evacuations.

3. Relay shelter openings and flood warnings person to person in English and Spanish, and run buddy checks for SRO residents

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FRONTLINE · SKEPTIC | INVENTORY: WINTER WEATHER ADVISORIES (ANAND 2025), WHICH TRANSFER POORLY

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Peer relays via PATH and River Park Foundation; Father Joe's; volunteers using SDHC's SRO list; City OES for translation	**Relay captains named by 15 Nov**	**Volunteer time; *unfunded*, small**	**People missing a same-day shelter opening or a flood warning**

The City's audit of the January 2024 flood (OCA-25-10, June 2025) found its plans “do not include plans for communicating… in languages other than English.” The Spanish flyers carried a different date and listed fewer sandbag sites than the English ones. Shelter activation notice goes out the same day, by press release and 211, so it reaches people with phones and news, not people in a riverbed. The action: trusted peers and outreach staff carry each activation in both languages, with the real intake rules (1501 Imperial from 4pm until full; Living Water reservations 1–4pm). Volunteers working from the Housing Commission's SRO inventory call isolated older and disabled tenants before each storm.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: the Inventory precedent (Anand 2025: earlier winter advisories reduced vehicle crashes) comes from snow, cars, and 11 states, so it supports lead time in general rather than this mechanism. It is also listed as forthcoming, not yet published. Nothing shows SRO residents face flood risk; the case for buddy checks rests on isolation and outages. The lens's proposal to use UNITE HERE Local 30 stewards has no agreement behind it, so it is optional.

4. Keep naloxone in hands through storm season by funding distribution staff, not kits

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · PHILANTHROPIST | INVENTORY: LOOSE ONLY (SUBSTANCE-USE REGULATION, HEAT AND VIOLENCE)

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Family Health Centers of San Diego (SafePoint), with outreach teams and shelters	**Staff in place by 1 Dec**	**~$100k for 2 staff over 5 months, only if no County contract already pays for them**	**Overdose deaths among people using alone during storms and shelter disruption**

The baseline killer here is not weather. The Medical Examiner recorded 592 homeless deaths countywide in 2022, 269 of them fentanyl-related, and 624 in 2023 (Voice of San Diego reporting; no later figures found). That steady toll will almost certainly exceed anything the storms add. Kits are free from California's Naloxone Distribution Project, so the binding resource is staff. FHCSD's SafePoint has distributed naloxone since 2002, including at a stop at Imperial Ave and 16th St. Community naloxone distribution is associated with lower overdose death rates: adjusted rate ratio 0.73 at low uptake and 0.54 above 100 enrolments per 100,000 people (Walley et al., *BMJ* 2013, 19 Massachusetts communities, observational).*

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: weak for the size of the effect. The lens's "~35 deaths averted" applies Coffin & Sullivan's 1 death averted per 227 kits (*Ann Intern Med* 2013, 95% CI 71–716). That figure is a lifetime simulation for pre-fentanyl heroin users, and California has already given out more than 7 million kits. Read it as an upper bound, not a forecast. Cold weather is linked to fatal overdose (25% higher odds at freezing temperatures in Connecticut and Rhode Island), but there is no evidence linking rain or storms to overdose, and San Diego rarely freezes. Whether SafePoint can hire in weeks is unverified, so ask FHCSD directly.

5. Clear the downtown storm drains and the Alpha 1 channel by 15 December

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · HISTORIAN · SKEPTIC | INVENTORY: FLOODPLAIN RESTORATION (2023), ADJACENT

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
City Stormwater Department	15 Dec	Existing maintenance budget; no figure published	Street flooding downtown; for Chollas, a repeat of the 2024 Southcrest flood

For the Gaslamp itself, the relevant asset is the downtown drain network. Chollas Creek is 3–5 miles east, so clearing it is a citywide equity item rather than a local one. Its record is damning: the 2019 maintenance plan rated South Chollas at a 5-year storm; the Alpha channel was scheduled for 2023–24 and not cleared before 22 January 2024; and one 15-person crew clears about four channels a year. Alpha 1 received a CEQA exemption in November 2024, and the Regional Water Board has cleared routine maintenance since 2021, so the "two-year permit" excuse no longer holds for this channel. The Mayor proclaimed a local emergency for the El Niño season on 2 October 2026, and the City says it is clearing more than 11 miles of channel.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: the mechanism is local and documented. A local proclamation does not waive Army Corps permits. Only 17% of City channels are sized for a 100-year storm, so clearing reduces the risk without removing it.

6. Vaccinate against hepatitis A and keep downtown restrooms open around the clock, as a year-round measure rather than an El Niño one

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | HISTORIAN · EMERGENCY MGR · PUBLIC HEALTH · PHILANTHROPIST | INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
County Public Health; City for restroom operations	Ongoing; a vaccination push in Nov alongside shelter activations	Existing County programmes; *unfunded* top-up	A repeat of the 2016–18 outbreak (589 cases, 20 deaths)

The 2016–18 outbreak was centred downtown. Half the cases were among people experiencing homelessness, whose odds of death were 3.9 times higher (95% CI 1.1–16.9; Peak et al., CDC). Cases rose again in 2023, about 63% of them among unhoused people in central San Diego, and the County urged vaccination in November 2025. Downtown's Portland Loos have a history of closures.

Transferability: verified history, but a weak El Niño link. The 2017 driver was lack of toilets and handwashing, which is a year-round condition, and no evidence was found that flooding drives hepatitis A downtown. It is listed because four lenses converged on it; the verifier's correction is that it should not be sold as storm preparation. No current vaccination-coverage figure exists for this population.

7. Household and business money: NFIP contents cover bought by about 1 November, plus CARE, FERA, and Medical Baseline enrolment

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | ECONOMIST | INVENTORY: FLOOD INSURANCE REFORM AND UPDATED FLOOD MAPS (2020), ADJACENT

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Gaslamp Quarter Association and Downtown San Diego Partnership to broadcast it; SDG&E for enrolment	~1 Nov for cover from 1 Dec (30-day wait)	Premiums; City CRS Class 7 gives a 15% discount	Uninsured property loss, and loss of power for medical devices

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Only 8,128 of about 1.15M county households had flood insurance in January 2024 (Rep. Vargas). After that flood, money moved weeks late: FEMA DR-4758 paid about $22.2M to 2,898 households after the declaration on 19 February 2024, and the San Diego Foundation's fund raised $1.35M. NFIP's 30-day wait means cover bought after about 1 November does not start until December, which is already into the peak. CARE (30–35% off) and FERA (18% off) cut bills. Medical Baseline is the enrolment that matters for life.

Transferability: this protects property and household finances, with low relevance to lives. The Gaslamp's flood zone was not verified, and its upland grid is probably Zone X (check at msc.fema.gov). The CPUC disaster protections under D.19-07-015 (no shutoffs, deposit waivers) are *probably not active*. They require a Governor's or President's declaration *and* disrupted utility service, and no SDG&E advice letter was found.

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WHO DOES WHAT

RACI CHART

R = Responsible (does the work) · **A** = Accountable (one per action; signs off and answers for it) · **C** = Consulted (asked before) · **I** = Informed (told after). Built from the owners named in the verified actions. No one here has been contacted or has agreed to a role; every row is a proposal.

Action	City Homelessness Strategies & Solutions	San Diego Housing Commission	PATH San Diego	San Diego River Park Foundation	SDFD Lifeguards & Park Rangers	City Office of Emergency Services	City Stormwater Dept	Father Joe's Villages & Living Water	Family Health Centers (SafePoint)	County Public Health (HHSA)	Santee Sheriff & Fire	Downtown Partnership & Gaslamp Quarter Assn	SDG&E	NWS San Diego
1. Channel walks before every Flood Watch	**A**	**I**	**R**	**R**	**R**	**C**					**R**			**C**
2. Shelter trigger, more nights, 16th & Newton move plan	**R**	**A**	**I**			**C**		**R**		**I**				**C**
3. Bilingual person-to-person relay; SRO buddy checks	**C**	**C**	**R**	**R**		**A**		**R**				**I**		
4. Naloxone distribution staff	**I**		**C**					**C**	**R**	**A**				
5. Downtown drains and Alpha 1 cleared by 15 Dec						**C**	**A/R**					**I**		**I**
6. Hepatitis A vaccination; 24-hour restrooms	**R**		**C**					**C**	**R**	**A**		**C**		
7. NFIP contents cover; CARE, FERA, Medical Baseline						**I**						**R**	**A/R**	

What the chart shows. **PATH and the River Park Foundation do the work on the two rows that reach people in the channels**, and the state grants that paid for that outreach are expiring, so their funding is the plan's biggest dependency. **Forester Creek needs a second owner**: it is in Santee, outside City jurisdiction, which is why the Santee Sheriff and Fire carry an R on row 1. **County Public Health is accountable for both health rows**, neither of which is really an El Niño action. **Row 7 has no public owner**: flood cover is bought household by household, so the Downtown Partnership and the Gaslamp Quarter Association can only broadcast it.

WHERE MONEY DOES THE MOST

FUNDING

The Philanthropist lens, reconciled against the ranked actions and verified. Placements are ranked by marginal lives saved per dollar. The envelope is bounded by what this place can spend before the peak, not by what it needs.

FLOOR	TARGET	CEILING	LARGEST UNCERTAINTY
$250k	~$891.5k	~$1.66M	The shelter bed-night rate ($66 is derived from contracts, not published), and whether SDHC will open on nights below the trigger

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Floor: $150k for outreach plus $100k for naloxone staff, which together cover the two causes that actually kill people here. **Target:** 60 extra activated nights × 162 beds × $66 = $641,520, plus $150k and $100k, for a total of $891,520. **Ceiling:** all ~99 unactivated winter nights × 162 × $66 = $1,058,508, plus $250k for naloxone at the lens's full figure, $150k for outreach, and $200k for sanitation if it can be verified, for a total of $1,658,508. Anything more needs new structures that cannot open before January. **The target fell 32.5% in verification**, from the lens's $1.32M, just under the one-third flag. If SDHC confirms a rate near $55 per bed-night, it falls to about $785k (–41%). The lens's original ceiling of $3.62M assumed 300 beds the sites do not have.

RECIPIENT	USE	AMOUNT	MECHANISM	BASIS	VERDICT
PATH San Diego, with San Diego River Park Foundation	Action 1: channel census and pre-storm walks, transport, and storage for belongings	$150k	Direct grant	~300 people × $500, an estimate with no published unit cost. Replaces expiring Encampment Resolution Fund outreach money	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED
SDHC Inclement Weather Shelter contract (Father Joe's Villages, Living Water Church)	Action 2: 60 more activated nights out of the ~99 currently dark	$641.5k	Top-up to existing contract	$66 per bed-night, derived from Alpha Project contract totals (2019, FY24), not a published rate	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED
Family Health Centers of San Diego (SafePoint)	Action 4: naloxone distribution staff	$100k	Direct grant, conditional	Coffin & Sullivan 2013 simulation (upper bound); kits free from the state. Release only if no County contract already covers these staff	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED
Downtown San Diego Partnership, Clean & Safe	Action 6: post-flood sanitation stock	$0 (was $200k)	n/a	No budget, past flood spending, or cost basis could be found; may duplicate what the PBID assessment already pays for	UNVERIFIED

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

RECIPIENT	USE	AMOUNT	MECHANISM	BASIS	VERDICT
~~SDHC: 150 extra shelter beds × 60 nights × $80~~	~~$720k bed expansion~~	~~$720k~~	n/a	The sites hold 162 beds at most, and the 69% average use shows beds are not the constraint. The $80 rate inflated an unsourced $61	CONTRAINDICATED

The funder's one thing: the cheapest life saved here is an overdose reversal, not a storm bed, and money spent buying naloxone is wasted because the state gives it away. Pay for the people who hand it out. The second-cheapest is a winter night the shelter already exists for but stays closed on, so buy nights, not beds.

DO NOT DO THIS — CONTRAINDICATED

Advice that circulates for this hazard and would cost lives here.

Suspend camping-ordinance enforcement across the board from November to March

CONTRAINDICATED AS WRITTEN

The Public Health and Skeptic lenses proposed this to avoid the overdose harm of displacement (Barocas et al., *JAMA* 2023: 974–2,175 extra overdose deaths per 10,000 people over 10 years, a 23-city *simulation*). But San Diego Municipal Code 63.0403(c) bans camping on waterway banks “at all times, regardless of the availability of shelter.” That is the provision that lets responders move people off the San Diego River before a storm. A blanket pause would switch off the one legal tool behind action 1.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Instead: suspend citations and arrests during shelter activations and storm weeks, but keep pre-storm moves out of waterways and channels, each paired with a real shelter offer. The City Auditor found that “most requests for shelter could not be met,” so the offer is the binding constraint.

Buy parametric flood insurance triggered by rainfall at Lindbergh Field

CONTRAINDICATED AS DESIGNED

The precedent is real. Fremont, CA buys cover using Floodbase data, placed by Amwins, that pays $200k once satellites observe at least 0.58 square miles of contiguous flooding. But the proposed San Diego version used a different trigger: 2.0 inches in 24 hours at KSAN. Rain at the airport does not track flooding in the Chollas Creek watershed, so the policy could pay out on a night when nobody floods, or pay nothing on a night like 22 January 2024 if the storm cell missed the gauge. The realistic payout is $100–250k, small next to FEMA aid, and nothing could be quoted, underwritten, and approved before December with confidence.

Instead: put this year's money into nights and outreach (actions 1 and 2). If the City wants risk transfer for 2027–28, scope a flood-extent product like Fremont's with the City as policyholder, then grant payouts on to shelter operators.

Fund 150 extra inclement-weather shelter beds

CONTRAINDICATED AS SPECIFIED

The Philanthropist's largest placement ($720k) assumed the sites could hold 300 beds. They hold 162, and average use in FY25 was 69%. The money would have bought capacity that cannot be installed, for a constraint that does not bind.

Instead: pay to open the existing beds on more of the ~99 winter nights the programme currently stays closed (funding table, row 2).

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
1916	Hatfield flood; Lower Otay Dam failed 27 Jan	14–30 dead depending on source; the city archive gives 22	Blamed on a hired rainmaker
1982–83	Strong El Niño: ~70 wet days against 40–45 normally; Scripps Pier destroyed	No death toll found	Coastal rebuilding
1997–98	Strong El Niño: 17.78 in at Lindbergh (~180% of normal); San Diego River 3.8 ft above flood stage, 24 Feb 1998	No death toll found	I-15 sinkhole repaired
2015–16	Strong El Niño that stayed dry: ~8 in	None	Taught the region that a forecast El Niño is not a forecast flood
2016–18	Hepatitis A outbreak, centred downtown	589 cases, 20 deaths	Restrooms, handwashing, and vaccination, about six months late; faulted by a state audit and the grand jury
Aug 2023	Tropical Storm Hilary	13 rescued from a Mission Valley riverbed encampment	Riverbed outreach continued
22 Jan 2024	2.73 in in one day during the 2023–24 El Niño; Chollas Creek flood; 16th & Newton shelter flooded	3 deaths investigated as possibly storm-related; >1,200 people in hotels 2.5 weeks later	FEMA paid ~$22.2M to 2,898 households; a 2025 audit found no non-English warning plan; the stormwater ballot measure was pulled
1 Jan 2026	16th & Newton Bridge Shelter flooded again	~325 people evacuated to the Balboa Park gym	No relocation plan found
2 Oct 2026	Local emergency proclaimed for the El Niño season	n/a	11+ miles of channel clearing; the 100,000-sandbag plan is still $300k short

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The recurrence nobody has noticed: both of San Diego's deadly floods came in the last week of January (1916 and 2024), and both were dismissed as freak events, blamed on a rainmaker in 1916 and called a “thousand-year storm” in 2024. The newer pattern is that the shelter system itself sits in the hazard zone. The same bridge shelter has flooded three times in eight years and is still there.

WHERE THE EXPERTS DISAGREE — UNRESOLVED

- **Storms are the threat** (Emergency manager, Historian, Skeptic) versus **overdose is the threat and storms only modulate it** (Public health, Philanthropist). About 600 homeless deaths a year against a handful of storm deaths favours the second view on volume. But storm deaths are concentrated, foreseeable, and preventable with tools already in place. Settling it needs Medical Examiner deaths for 2024–25 by week, to see whether overdose rises in storm weeks.
- **The 2023 camping ban pushed people into the flood channels** (six lenses) versus **encampment locations “did not significantly change”** (City Auditor, April 2026). Riverbed counts also fell from 323 (Nov 2025, outreach log) to ~148 (2026 PIT). The channel risk is real either way, but its size is contested.
- **Fund the City's $300k sandbag gap** (Economist) versus **sandbags protect doorways, not people** (Skeptic, finance verifier). Sandbags do not touch the ways people die in floods here: in vehicles and in channels. The verifier sided with the Skeptic, and so does this report. It is a reasonable property spend, but not a life-saving one.

WHAT NOBODY COVERED — BLIND SPOT

No lens counted **power-dependent residents**: people on home oxygen, ventilators, or dialysis in ZIP 92101, where the HHS emPOWER dataset would give a Medicare count. Storm outages are the usual way a coastal winter kills housed people. No lens addressed the **autumn Santa Ana heat and wildfire smoke** that can arrive before the rains, either. No lens looked at **visitors**: convention and Petco Park crowds driving through flooded underpasses on event nights. Nationally, most flood deaths with known circumstances involve vehicles. Any of these could add an action above rank 5.

HOW TO READ THIS — METHOD

The panel is author-built. Seven simulated expert lenses were used to generate these recommendations. Where they agree, that is a strong hypothesis, not a consensus of the field. Every recommendation was then independently checked for evidence, transferability to this location, and

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

feasibility before the peak; the verdict tags carry the result.

Mortality figures are resolved at Climate Impact Lab impact-region scale, roughly 300,000 people, and are not neighbourhood figures. The El Niño projection covers *heat only*; drought, flood, fire, smoke, and crop failure are additional to it and are carried here by the historical record rather than by a published number.

HOW THIS BRIEFING WAS PRODUCED

METHODOLOGY

- **Scope.** The location was taken as given: Gaslamp Quarter, downtown San Diego, California. Climate Impact Lab impact region, as this report records it: San Diego County, CA, *inferred* rather than resolved on the Impact Map. Mortality figures exist only at that scale; sub-city detail is used for hazard exposure and action design, not for death counts. Where lenses used administrative data, the unit is named: City of San Diego (PIT count), County (Medical Examiner), and the Downtown Partnership's monthly downtown count. None of these is the Gaslamp itself, which sits at the western edge of the East Village cluster.
- **Exposure.** Climate Impact Lab, *451,000 at Risk* (September 2026, pre-peer-review): ECMWF SEAS5 seasonal forecasts (51-member ensemble) applied to temperature–mortality relationships across 24,378 regions, against a 1996–2025 baseline, for June 2026 – February 2027. It covers heat only. It is never added to the Impact Map's long-run projections or quoted from the map's GDP-denominated mortality. Heat is not the dominant hazard here, so the historical record carries the hazard instead of a borrowed number.
- **Expert panel.** Seven simulated expert lenses (emergency manager, public health scientist, frontline responder, skeptic, economist, historian, and philanthropist) each researched this place independently and in parallel, from web sources, to a fixed brief.
- **Reconciliation.** Duplicate actions were merged and backing lenses recorded. Convergence was tested for shared bias, meaning whether the evidence behind an agreed action came from a setting like this one, before it counted in an action's favour. Here, the four-lens hepatitis A convergence was demoted because its El Niño link did not survive. Contradictions were kept, not resolved by dropping a side. Actions were ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak, each was given a named payer or marked unfunded, and the funding placements were reconciled against the ranked list.
- **Verification.** Five separate verifier agents checked 11 recommendations and the four funding placements on three tests: evidence (the primary source and its effect size), transferability (whether that evidence came from somewhere like here), and feasibility (whether it can be done here before the peak). Financial actions were also checked for availability in this jurisdiction, a named payer, a trigger threshold, and whether they already exist. The funding envelope was checked for real recipients, published unit costs, and duplication, then re-summed.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

- **Verdicts.** *Confirmed*: evidence, transferability, and feasibility all hold. *Partially confirmed*: holds after the corrections shown. *Unverified*: could not be checked to a primary source. *Contraindicated*: would do harm or waste the window here.
- **Adaptation Inventory.** Consulted, by driving the inventory's map interface in a browser, because its download sits behind a sign-up form. The US filter returns 19 entries; all 19 titles were read, and three in full: *Winter weather advisories* (Anand 2025), *Change in forecast quality* (Shrader, Bakkensen & Lemoine 2023, NBER: 50% more accurate forecasts would save about 2,200 lives a year), and *Substance abuse regulation policies* (Pavanello & Zappalà 2024). *Floodplain restoration* and *Flood insurance reform* were matched by title only. No US entry covers shelter activation, pre-storm outreach, naloxone, or hepatitis A, so those actions are tagged “none found”.
- **Health wording.** Passages where a wording error could hurt someone (naloxone and overdose) are marked "* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing." They were checked against published sources, not by a health professional. They are suggestions, not medical advice, and anyone passing them on should confirm them with a doctor, pharmacist, nurse, or community health worker first. The marker was added on 2 November 2026.
- **Rules.** No cost is derived by dividing a published total without the division being shown and labelled. The $66 bed-night rate is contract-derived and flagged as such. No local figure is invented; where data is thin, the report says so.
- **Limits.** The panel and verifiers are AI research agents working from web-available sources, not human experts, and no one in this place was interviewed. No San Diego hypothermia or cold-exposure death data was found. No Medical Examiner homeless-death figures after 2023 were found. The Gaslamp's FEMA flood zone was not checked. The City Council's ratification of the 2 October proclamation could not be confirmed. Several rescue counts rest on TV-station reporting rather than agency records.

References · verified by Phase 5 unless marked. City Auditor OCA-26-07 highlights (verified) · OCA-26-07 full audit (verified) · OCA-25-10 flood audit, NBC San Diego (verified) · River Park Foundation pre-storm outreach, 10News (verified) · Hilary riverbed rescues, FOX 5 (verified, TV report) · Jan 2024 storm deaths, NBC San Diego (corrected) · OES El Niño memo, 11 Sep 2026 (verified) · Inclement Weather Shelter activation, Feb 2026 (verified) · IWS triggers, Jan 2026 (verified) · 16th & Newton flood, 1 Jan 2026 (verified) · 20th & B relocation, Feb 2024 (verified) · SDHC storm shelter programmes (verified) · Alpha Bridge Shelter contract (basis for the derived rate) · SDMC 63.0403 waterway enforcement bulletin (verified) · Barocas et al., JAMA 2023 (verified, simulation) · Chollas Creek channel reports, CBS 8 (verified) · Alpha 1 CEQA exemption (verified) · Local emergency, 2 Oct 2026 (verified) · Sandbag gap and channel capacity (verified) · Walley et al., BMJ 2013 (verified) · Coffin & Sullivan 2013, summary (verified, simulation) · Cold weather and fatal overdose (verified) · Homeless deaths 2022–23, Voice of San Diego (corrected) · California Naloxone Distribution Project (verified) · Peak et al., hepatitis A, CDC (verified) · County hepatitis A releases (verified) · East Village restrooms (verified) · Fremont parametric cover, Floodbase (verified) · Fremont, Governing (verified) · City CRS class (verified) · NFIP uptake, Rep. Vargas (verified) · FEMA DR-4758 (verified) · San Diego Foundation flood fund (corrected) · HHAP Round 6 (verified) · Expiring encampment grants, KPBS (verified) · Encampment Resolution Fund (verified) · SDHC SRO inventory (verified) · Anand, winter advisories

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

(verified, forthcoming) · 1916 flood, city archive (lens, not re-verified) · 1997–98 record (lens, not re-verified) · 1982–83 and 2015–16, KPBS (lens, not re-verified) · Post-flood displacement (lens, not re-verified)

Exposure data · Climate Impact Lab, 451,000 at Risk · Impact Map · Adaptation Inventory (US)

Generated 8 October 2026 for the Gaslamp Quarter, San Diego. El Niño Ready is volunteer-run and is not affiliated with Climate Week NYC, The Climate Group, or Columbia University.

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